(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

Things you can do to help menopause and perimenopause symptoms

Lifestyle changes for perimenopause and menopause

Eating well, exercising and looking after your mental wellbeing can help with symptoms during perimenopause and menopause.

It can also help you keep as well as possible in the future.

Do

- try to get plenty of rest, including keeping to regular sleep routines
- try to eat a healthy, balanced diet
- eat calcium-rich food like milk, yoghurt and kale, if you can, to keep your bones healthy
- exercise regularly, with focus on weight-bearing exercises to build strength as this can help protect against weakening bones
- try relaxing things such as yoga, tai chi or meditation
- talk to other people going through the same thing, like family, friends or colleagues
- talk to a doctor before taking herbal supplements or complementary medicines
- talk to a doctor about hormonal contraception if you need to – HRT is not contraception

Don’t

- ✗ do not smoke as this can make menopause symptoms worse
- ✗ try not to drink more than the recommended alcohol limit – it may affect your symptoms

Other ways to help perimenopause and menopause symptoms

How to ease mood changes

It's common to have mood swings, low mood and anxiety around the time of the menopause and perimenopause.

Try to:

- get as much rest as you can
- exercise regularly
- do relaxing activities

Cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/cognitive-behavioural-therapy-cbt/) is a type of talking therapy that can help with a low mood and feelings of anxiety. It can also help with sleep problems.

How to ease hot flushes and night sweats

You can try:

- wearing lightweight clothing
- keeping your bedroom cool at night
- taking a cool shower, using a fan or having a cold drink
- finding ways to reduce your stress level (Link: www.nhs.uk/mental-health/self-help/guides-tools-and-activities/tips-to-reduce-stress/)
- to avoid or reduce potential triggers, such as spicy food, caffeine, hot drinks, smoking and alcohol
- to exercise (Link: www.nhs.uk/live-well/exercise/) regularly
- to keep to a healthy weight (Link: www.nhs.uk/live-well/healthy-weight/)

Cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/cognitive-behavioural-therapy-cbt/) can also help manage hot flushes.

How to ease vaginal dryness

There are vaginal moisturisers or lubricants you can get without a prescription at a pharmacy.

You can talk to a pharmacist, in private, if you'd like help to decide which moisturiser is right for you.

If you're having sex and using condoms, do not use an oil-based lubricant as this can damage condoms. Water-based lubricants are available.

There are other treatments for vaginal dryness that a doctor can prescribe, such as HRT (hormone replacement therapy) or hormonal treatment (creams, pessaries, gel or vaginal rings).

Find out about treatment for vaginal dryness (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/hormone-replacement-therapy-hrt/vaginal-oestrogen/).

Protecting against weak bones

You can try to:

- exercise regularly, particularly focusing on strength exercises (Link: www.nhs.uk/live-well/exercise/strength-exercises/), where your feet and legs support your weight (like walking, running or dancing) and resistance exercises (for example, using weights)
- eat a healthy diet that includes plenty of fruit, vegetables and sources of calcium, such as milk, yoghurt and kale
- get some sunlight on your skin as this triggers the production of vitamin D (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/vitamins-and-minerals/vitamin-d/), which can help keep your bones healthy
- take vitamin D supplements
- stop smoking and cut down on alcohol

Taking HRT can also reduce the risk of osteoporosis.

Find out more about preventing osteoporosis (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/osteoporosis/prevention/)

Find out more

- Reducing health risks after menopause on the British Nutrition Foundation website (Link: https://www.nutrition.org.uk/nutrition-for/women/menopause/reducing-health-risks-after-the-menopause-with-nutrition-and-diet/)
- Sleep problems on the Better Health website (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/every-mind-matters/mental-health-issues/sleep/)
- Menopause and weight gain on the Women's Health Concern website, (PDF only, 84KB) (Link: https://www.womens-health-concern.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/06/31-WHC-FACTSHEET-Weight-Gain-and-menopause-JUNE2023-A.pdf)

More in Menopause and perimenopause (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/menopause-and-perimenopause/)

What are menopause and perimenopause? (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/menopause-and-perimenopause/what-are-menopause-and-perimenopause/)

Symptoms (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/menopause-and-perimenopause/symptoms/)

Treatment (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/menopause-and-perimenopause/treatment/)

Things you can do

Support (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/menopause-and-perimenopause/help-and-support/)

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